

ApprovalFlow

Global Administrator Manual

Creating and looking after the customer organisations on an installation

This manual is for the people who run an ApprovalFlow installation for more than one organisation: creating customers, giving each one its address and first administrator, suspending and restoring access, and helping a customer administrator when something goes wrong. It assumes the server is already installed - that is covered in docs/DEPLOYMENT-IIS.md. What a customer administrator does inside their own organisation is covered in the Administrator Manual.

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CHAPTER 1

Overview

One installation can host many **customers** (organisations). Each customer has its own address, its own forms, its own people and its own data; none of them can see any of the others. The **global management console** is where customers are created and looked after. It is a separate site with a separate sign-in: your account there is not a user account in any customer, and no customer administrator can see it, deactivate it or reset its key.

The two kinds of administrator

Role	What it can do
Global administrator (you)	Create customers, rename them, move them to another address, suspend and restore them, remove them (with a 30-day window to restore), grant or remove the Admin role inside a customer, reset a customer administrator key, change a customer settings, choose a folder of its own for a customer's files, start a time-limited support session, and add or deactivate other global administrators.
Customer administrator	Everything inside one organisation: forms, approval chains, lookups, requests, its own users and its own settings. Nothing outside it.

NOTE

You cannot read a customer requests, forms or documents from the console. There is no page that shows them and no setting that turns one on. When you genuinely need to see what a customer sees, use a **support session** (chapter 5), which is visible to them and recorded in their own audit log.

Signing in

The console is at **/global** on the installation address, for example <https://approvals.yourcompany.com/global>, or on its own address if your installation was set up with one. Sign in with your email address and 6-digit password key, exactly like a customer user. Five wrong keys lock the account for 15 minutes.

Once signed in, **Help** in the top-right corner opens this manual in a new tab. Only signed-in global administrators can open it; the link it opens works for a few minutes only, so open it again from **Help** rather than from a saved address. Customer administrators get their own manuals from **Help** in their portal: the Administrator Manual and the User Manual.

The icon beside **Help** switches the colours: **System** (follow your computer), **Light** or **Dark**, one per click. It is remembered in your browser only. The console always has a **navy** top bar and sign-in panel, where customer portals have a black one, so you can tell at a glance whether you are in the console or inside a customer (for example during a support session).

The very first global administrator is created on the server with a command, because there is nobody yet to create one in the console:

- `npm run seed:platform-admin -- --email you@example.com --displayName "Your Name"`
- A random 6-digit key is printed **once**. Sign in with it, then change it.
- Run it again with `--reset-key` for somebody who has lost theirs.

After that, further global administrators are added in the console itself, on the **Administrators** page (chapter 7).

CHAPTER 2

The customer list

The console opens on the list of every customer on the installation. The tiles above it count active customers, people, requests in progress, and failed emails across all of them - a quick check that nothing is stuck anywhere.

Column	Meaning
Customer	The organisation name. A Suspended badge means nobody there can sign in.
Address	The host name that organisation is reached at.
People	Active user accounts in that organisation.
Forms	Active forms.
Requests	Total requests, and how many are still in progress.
Last activity	The most recent audited event of any kind there. A customer with no activity for a long time is worth asking about.
Open	Opens that customer portal in a new tab - the sign-in page, not a way in.

Recent management activity below the list is the last 20 things global administrators did, with who did them. It is a summary of the platform audit log, which records every action taken in this console and can never be edited or deleted.

CHAPTER 3

Creating a customer

Choose **New customer**. You are creating two things at once: the organisation, and the first person who can administer it.

Field	What to put in it
Organisation name	What the customer calls itself. It appears on their sign-in page until they set a display name of their own.
Address	The short name their sub-site is reached at, filled in for you from the organisation name. Lowercase letters, digits and hyphens. Choose carefully: changing it later changes the address people have bookmarked.
Full host name	Only if this customer is to be reached at a name of its own, such as approvals.acme.com. Leave it blank for the standard address on this installation.
First administrator email and name	The person who will set the organisation up. They do not need an account yet - this creates it.
Folder for this customer's files (optional)	A folder on the server or a network share - D:\CustomerFiles\Acme or \fileserver\approvals\Acme - where this customer's PDFs and approvers' documents are saved instead of the database. Leave it blank to keep them in the database. See File storage in chapter 4; it can also be set later.

On **Create customer** the organisation, its request numbering, its settings and its first administrator are created together, in one step that either fully succeeds or does nothing at all. A **first sign-in key** is then shown:

NOTE

The key is shown **once** and is not stored anywhere in readable form, so it cannot be looked up later. Pass it to that administrator through a channel you trust, not in the same email as the address. If it is lost, use **Reset key** (chapter 4) rather than creating a second customer.

A customer whose address or host name is already taken is refused, so two customers can never share an address.

What the new administrator does next

1. Signs in at their own address with the key you gave them, and changes it.
2. Sets their branding and sign-up rules on the **Settings** page.
3. Builds their first form and its approval chain.
4. Tells their colleagues the address - everyone else creates their own account at first sign-in.

All of that is their work, not yours; the Administrator Manual walks them through it.

CHAPTER 4

Looking after a customer

Open a customer from the list to see its detail page.

Address and status

Rename the organisation, move it to another host name, or change the notification address that alerts go to when nobody more specific applies. Moving a customer to a new host name only works once DNS points that name at this installation - arrange that first, or people will find nothing there.

Suspending and restoring

Suspend this customer stops that organisation completely: nobody can sign in, and everybody already signed in is signed out within moments, including anyone holding a valid session. Their data is untouched, and **Reactivate** puts everything back exactly as it was.

NOTE

Suspension is the right tool for non-payment, an offboarding, or a security incident. It is not a way to archive an organisation - a suspended customer still occupies its address, and its scheduled reminders stop while it is suspended.

Removing a customer

When an organisation has left for good, you can remove it. Removing does not delete anything straight away: the customer is frozen for **30 days**, during which you can restore it. After that, everything it owns is deleted permanently: its people, forms, approval chains, requests and their decisions, lookups, settings, its own audit log, and its stored PDFs and emails on this server.

1. Suspend the customer first. Removing is not available while anybody can still sign in.
2. In the **Remove this customer** section at the bottom of its page, type the customer's short address name (its slug) exactly as shown.
3. Choose **Remove customer**. The customer list shows it as **Removed**, with the date its data will be deleted.

While a customer is removed, nobody can sign in, nothing about it can be changed, and its address stays reserved. To undo a removal, open the customer and choose **Restore this customer** before the deletion date. It comes back suspended, exactly as it was; choose **Reactivate** when its people should be able to sign in again.

NOTE

Once the 30 days are over the deletion happens automatically and cannot be undone. If the customer might want their records, export what they need before that date. The global activity log keeps a permanent record of who removed which customer, any restore, and the final deletion. The grace period is set on the server with `TENANT_REMOVAL_DAYS`.

Administrators

The **Administrators** section lists the people with the Admin role in that organisation, and whether each has set a password key yet.

Action	What happens
Add administrator	Gives the Admin role to somebody who already has an account there. It cannot create an account, so a brand new person must first sign in once, or be added by one of the customer's own administrators under Users > Add people .
Remove	Takes the Admin role away. The account itself stays, with its other roles.
Reset key	Forgets that person password key. At their next sign-in they prove their email address with a code and choose a new key. You never see either key.

NOTE

Leaving an organisation with no administrator at all locks its own people out of their configuration - they would need you to grant the role again. Check the list before removing the last one.

File storage

By default a customer's closed-request PDFs and its approvers' documents are kept in the database. Under **File storage** you can give it a folder of its own instead: type the path in **Folder for this customer's files** and choose **Use this folder**.

- Use a full path: a folder on a drive of the server (**D:\CustomerFiles\Acme**, not a whole drive) or a network share (**\\fileserver\approvals\Acme**). The folder is created if it does not exist.
- The Windows account the app runs as needs **Modify** permission on the folder (and on the share, for a network path). The app proves it can write there before saving the setting; if it cannot, it says why and nothing changes.
- Files are saved in **one sub-folder per day** - the day each request was submitted, named like 2026-09-28, by the server's clock. A request's PDF and all its documents land in the same day's folder. PDFs keep their usual names; documents are named after their request and step (REQ-000014_Step-1_Supplier quote.pdf). Nothing is ever overwritten.
- The database keeps each file's path and fingerprint. A file changed or removed outside the app is refused, not shown - so back the folder up, and restore from the backup if that happens.
- Changing or clearing the folder (**Keep new files in the database instead**) affects **new files only** : every file already saved stays where it is and still opens.
- The customer is never shown the server path. When a removed customer is finally deleted, the files the app wrote for it are deleted too - nothing else in the folder is touched.

Settings

The lower half of the page is the customer **Settings** page - branding, who may register and the sender address - exactly as their own administrator sees it, and edited the same way. Use it to help somebody who is stuck; the change is recorded in their audit log with your email address beside it, so nothing you do here is invisible to them.

CHAPTER 5

Support sessions

When a customer administrator needs help with something you cannot see from the console, **Start support session** opens their portal as one of their administrators. It is deliberately narrow:

- It lasts **30 minutes** and cannot be renewed silently - start a new one if you need longer.
- It acts as one of **their** administrators, so it can do no more than that person could. It is not a higher level of access.
- The portal shows a banner for the whole session, so anybody looking over their shoulder sees it.
- The start, and the reason you type, go into their audit log as **user.impersonation_started** and into the platform log.
- Every entry created during the session is stamped **impersonatedByPlatformAdmin**, so their auditor can tell your actions from theirs forever afterwards.

Type a reason - a ticket number is ideal. Then choose **Start support session** and **Open the portal**. A suspended customer cannot be opened; reactivate it first if that is really what you want.

NOTE

Treat a support session as you would remote control of somebody desk: do what was asked and nothing else. Prefer the console settings page for configuration changes, and a support session only for the things that genuinely need their view of the system.

CHAPTER 6

Addresses, email and data

How an address decides the organisation

The address in the browser is what decides which organisation a request belongs to - not anything the browser sends. A person who exists in two customers has **two separate accounts** with separate password keys, and the one that answers is the one whose address they opened. A key from one organisation never works at another address.

Every link in every email uses that organisation own address, so an approver who clicks an emailed link always lands in the right organisation.

Adding a customer to an installation

1. With a wildcard DNS record and certificate in place (see docs/DEPLOYMENT-IIS.md), a new customer needs **no server work at all** - creating it in the console is enough.
2. A customer that wants a name of its own needs a DNS entry, a certificate and an IIS binding for that name, and then its **Full host name** set on the detail page.

What is shared and what is not

Kept apart per customer	Shared by the installation
Forms, requests, documents, lookups, users, audit log	The server itself, the database, and the mail server
Branding, sign-up rules, sender address	The default values those settings fall back to
Archived PDFs and approvers' documents (in the database, or in the customer's own folder)	The database, or the server or share holding the folders

Separation is enforced in the database, not only in the pages: every table carries the organisation, child rows can only point at a parent in the same organisation, and any query that forgets to say which organisation it means is rejected rather than answered.

CHAPTER 7

Global administrators

The **Administrators** page, in the top bar of the console, lists everybody who can sign in to the console, and lets any global administrator look after the others.

Action	What happens
New global administrator	Enter their email address and name . A 6-digit sign-in key is generated and shown once - pass it to them through a channel you trust. They should change it after signing in.
New key	Gives somebody who has lost their key a new generated one, shown once. Their old key stops working.
Deactivate	Blocks that person from the console at once and ends any session they have open. Their history in the activity log stays.
Reactivate	Lets a deactivated administrator sign in again.

- Nobody can deactivate themselves or give themselves a new key here, so there is always at least one active global administrator.
- The same page has **Change my key**, for your own key: enter the current key and the new one twice.
- Every change is recorded in the global activity log with who made it.

IMPORTANT

A global administrator can create, change, suspend and remove every customer, and manage the other global administrators. Add only people who need that.

CHAPTER 8

Everyday tasks

Task	What to do
A new customer is joining	Create it (chapter 3), send the address and the first-sign-in key separately, and point their administrator at the Administrator Manual.
The first administrator lost the key before using it	Open the customer, choose Reset key beside them. They set a new key with an emailed code at next sign-in.
Their administrator has left	Add the replacement (they must have signed in once), then remove the old one. Never leave an organisation with no administrator.
They say emails are not arriving	Check Failed emails on the customer list, then their sender address in Settings. A wrong From address is the usual cause; the mail server itself is installation-wide.
They report something you cannot see	Ask for the request number, then start a support session with that number as the reason.
Non-payment or an incident	Suspend the customer. Nothing is deleted, and reactivating restores it exactly.
A customer has left for good	Suspend it, then Remove customer at the bottom of its page. You can restore it for 30 days; after that everything it owns is deleted for good.
Somebody asks what you did in their organisation	Their own audit log answers it: every action of yours is in there, and support-session actions are stamped as such.
A customer wants example forms to start from	On the server run npm --prefix server run sample:forms -- --tenant <address name> (for example --tenant acme). It adds five sample forms with approval chains - Leave Request, Mileage Reimbursement, IT Access & Equipment Request, Records Retrieval Request and Secure Destruction Authorization - using that customer's own approvers and its Departments and Schools lookup tables if it has them. A form that already exists is left alone, so it is safe to run twice. The customer needs an administrator and at least one approver first. The Administrator Manual describes the forms.
A new global administrator is joining	On the Administrators page choose New global administrator and pass them the key shown (chapter 7).
A global administrator has left	On the Administrators page choose Deactivate beside them.
A customer wants its files on its own drive or share	Set File storage on its page (chapter 4) after giving the app's account Modify permission on the folder.

Keeping your own account safe

- Your account can create, suspend and enter every organisation on the installation, so it deserves more care than a customer account: a key nobody else knows, and not one you use anywhere else.
- Sign out when you are finished, particularly on a shared machine. A support session token stops working on its own, but your console session does not.
- Give each person their own global administrator account rather than sharing one - the platform audit log is only useful if it names a person.